

Episode 17: Once Upon a Time... (12) "Atatatatata..." "Bushu! Hidebu!"

A CD I ordered online recently arrived - *Future Boy Conan Complete Music Collection*.

When I told A-san, who helps with work, "The *Conan* music collection is great!" she gave me a puzzled look...

"Eh? Tsujita-san listens to Conan? I mean, do you watch Conan?"

"Eh? Not 'watching' but 'watched'..."

"Hm? Hm?"

The *Conan* she was referring to was "*Detective Conan*"! Incidentally, she was born in 1982. Ah, *Future Boy Conan* was anime from before you were born (laughs). A slight generation gap over "*Conan*" (bitter laugh).

Well then.

Well, 1986 opened with the theatrical work "*GeGeGe no Kitaro: Yokai Daisenso*" (actually, Toei Animation's website "Work Lineup" lists the release date as March 15, 1985, but this is a mistake for 1986), but around the same production period, Toei Doga was working on another major theatrical work. The title was "*Hokuto no Ken: Seikimatsu Kyuseishu Densetsu*". A new theatrical work for the same series that was serialised in "Weekly Shonen Jump" and had begun TV animation broadcast the previous fall, gaining considerable popularity.

Director: Ashida Toyoo, **Direction:** Umezawa Atsutoshi, **Character Design/Animation Director:** Suda Masami, **Art Director:** Tanaka Sukeyuki. Colour direction had **Fujise-san**, who handled TV series colours, with **Tsukada-san** (*Slam Dunk*, *One Piece*) helping. Not just me but all Toei Doga inspection members at the time were drafted to help inspect this TP delivery.

As I wrote before, the system then was that people with free time from their own works and jobs would help with theatrical work cel delivery finishing inspection. Furthermore, during pre-editing or pre-dubbing photography crunches, under department manager instructions, we'd stop our own work to prioritise helping with cel delivery inspection.

I, who had the theatrical *Kitaro*, inevitably participated in helping. Or rather, *Kitaro* proceeded very precisely on schedule and was actually almost completed by the end of the previous year.

This *Hokuto no Ken* had various problems with TV series production finishing work. As I wrote long ago, Toei Doga works back then were mainly "shadowless" works, but this *Hokuto no Ken*, due to the work's nature, absolutely had "No.1 shadow," "No.2 shadow," "BL shadow," and even "highlights." Work volume increased while finishing unit costs remained the same, plus no schedule - finishing production companies were avoiding it.

So for the theatrical version, animation density naturally exceeded TV.

"Challenging depictions of scattered internal organs and brain matter that couldn't be drawn on TV" was one of this theatrical version's "selling points." So animation drew each intestinal fold more finely and boldly, colour direction used reference books to specify colours in detail, and painting this required even more finishing work. Moreover, finishing was much more overseas than domestic production companies. Roughness inevitably stood out. Hence cel delivery inspection and retake processing took incredibly long.

Day after day, battling blood splatters (laughs). No matter how strictly we checked, retakes appeared. And unlike now with digital, it took time to photograph, develop at labs, watch rush film with all staff in screening rooms - then discovering "colour mismatch" retakes. An indescribably unpleasant atmosphere would flow through screening rooms (bitter laugh).

With retakes not decreasing, at one point production staff K-san stood up in the screening room and declared:

"Listen! 'Paka-paka' is retake, but 'paka' is OK! Listen! One 'paka' is OK!"

More pressure for us finishing inspectors (bitter laugh). But anyway, for places that went "paka," we painted them black all over with black markers (finishing favourite "Pentel Name Pen") (laughs). This technique worked because *Hokuto no Ken* had many "BL shadows."

Somehow completing it this way. At the time, barely 2 weeks before release, staff first screening was held at Toei Studios screening room. However, watching the first screening, we inspection folks were disappointed. Apparently for "self-regulation" for film ratings, all splatter scenes were crushed from above with what was called "video processing." Even cuts with realistic pink intestines scattering that had been so difficult, cuts with brain matter scattered with blood splashes - all beautifully turned silhouette-style... Hmm.

Incidentally, now if you show "hidebu!" cuts directly like this, with [PG-12] or [PG-15], regulations are much stricter than back then, so children couldn't come see them in theatres, making it even worse box office-wise.

I recently discovered *Theatrical Hokuto no Ken Film Book* (volumes 1 & 2) from my parents' bookshelf! Looking at it intently after so long, seeing it anew like this, the limitations of Toei paints back then are quite obvious (bitter laugh).

Come to think of it, when the video was released, I think I bought it through internal company sales... I lent it to someone and that was it... Anyone who remembers, please contact me! (laughs)

What I can't forget from that time was during pre-editing *Hokuto no Ken* crunch when help was called and we were all working at night, listening to "Tunnels All Night Nippon" when a news bulletin came on. It was news that Space Shuttle **Challenger had exploded. Late night January 28th.**

(07.06.05)